

Pascal's wager

Today, it is generally agreed that there can be no logical proof either way for the existence of God, and that this is purely a matter of faith. Philosophical speculation on the subject, however, continued well into the so-called 'Age of Reason'. One novel take on the problem was raised by the mathematician Blaise Pascal in the 17th century. 'Pascal's wager' examines whether, given that we can have no proof of His existence, it is a better bet to believe in God or not. Pascal weighs up the pros and cons in terms of the consequences: if God exists and I deny his existence, I run the risk of eternal damnation; if He exists and I accept His existence, I earn eternal life in paradise; but if He doesn't exist, it will make no difference to me. On balance, then, it is a safer bet to believe in His existence. Although Pascal's wager is an interesting exercise in logic and rudimentary game theory, it is based on some shaky premises – we are asked to assume that God bases His decision on my afterlife on my belief in Him, that He, too, is a rational being and that heaven and hell also exist.

	God exists	God does not exist
Believe in God	Infinite good	No difference
Do not believe in God	Infinite bad	No difference